

Americans Paid \$43B More at the Pump — What the Iran War Data Actually Shows

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Context: On February 28, 2026, the United States and Israel launched strikes on Iran, triggering Iranian closure of the Strait of Hormuz — a critical chokepoint for global oil supply. This report uses public EIA gas price data and market prices for the six largest Western oil companies to measure the actual impact on U.S. consumers and oil company shareholders. All figures are computed deterministically from public data sources. No opinion. No advocacy.

TOTAL EXTRA
CONSUMER SPEND

\$43.2B

above pre-war
baseline

Mar 2 – 2026-06-08 · all US
drivers

GAS PRICE — PRE-WAR

\$2.796

per gallon

Week of 2026-02-23 · EIA
regular grade

GAS PRICE — PEAK

\$4.353

+\$1.557 (+55.7%)

Week of 2026-05-11

EXTRA COST AT PEAK

\$0.58B

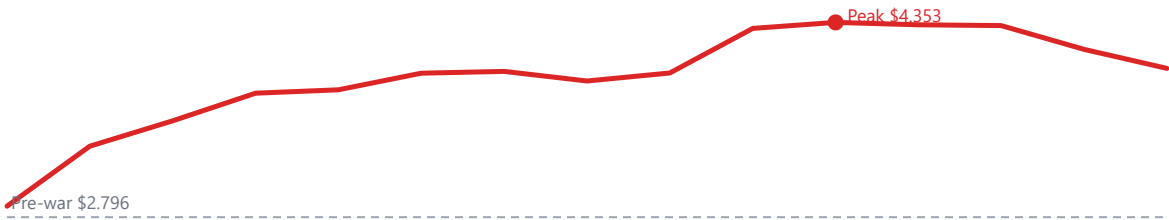
per day at peak

~370M gallons/day US
consumption

U.S. REGULAR GASOLINE PRICE — WEEKLY (EIA)

GASREGCOVW · DETERMINISTIC

Dashed line = pre-war baseline (\$2.796/gal) · Red line = actual weekly price · ★ = peak



Week	Price (\$/gal)	vs Pre-War	% Change	Extra Cost/Day
2026-03-02	\$2.884	+0.088	+3.1%	\$33M/day
2026-03-09	\$3.364	+0.568	+20.3%	\$210M/day
2026-03-16	\$3.566	+0.770	+27.5%	\$285M/day
2026-03-23	\$3.788	+0.992	+35.5%	\$367M/day
2026-03-30	\$3.814	+1.018	+36.4%	\$377M/day
2026-04-06	\$3.947	+1.151	+41.2%	\$426M/day
2026-04-13	\$3.962	+1.166	+41.7%	\$431M/day
2026-04-20	\$3.885	+1.089	+38.9%	\$403M/day

Week	Price (\$/gal)	vs Pre-War	% Change	Extra Cost/Day
2026-04-27	\$3.948	+1.152	+41.2%	\$426M/day
2026-05-04	\$4.305	+1.509	+54.0%	\$558M/day
2026-05-11 ★ PEAK	\$4.353	+1.557	+55.7%	\$576M/day
2026-05-18	\$4.334	+1.538	+55.0%	\$569M/day
2026-05-25	\$4.327	+1.531	+54.8%	\$566M/day
2026-06-01	\$4.138	+1.342	+48.0%	\$497M/day
2026-06-08	\$3.986	+1.190	+42.6%	\$440M/day

FACT-CHECK — THE "\$300M/DAY TO BILLIONAIRES" CLAIM

✓ **CONFIRMED** — **Gas prices did spike sharply.** U.S. regular gasoline rose from \$2.796/gal to a peak of \$4.353/gal — a 55.7% increase. At peak, U.S. consumers paid an estimated \$0.58B extra per day. Total estimated extra consumer spend through 2026-06-08: \$43.2B. This is a real transfer of consumer dollars to oil producers — not disputed.

✓ **CONFIRMED** — **Oxfam's \$300M/day math is arithmetically correct.** Oxfam reported \$23.5B in wealth gains to 41 billionaires over approximately 75 days = \$313M/day. The arithmetic is accurate.

✗ **MISLEADING** — **"From your gas tank to their hands."** The actual six-company total market cap gain was \$-29.5B — shared across hundreds of millions of shareholders worldwide including pension funds, 401(k)s, and index funds. The 41 billionaires' \$23.5B is their proportional slice of the total, not a direct transfer from gas pumps. Stock price gains are also unrealized paper wealth — not cash.

✗ **MISLEADING** — **Stock gains were largely temporary.** All six oil stocks peaked in late March/early April then gave back most gains as ceasefire negotiations progressed. By May 15, the six companies collectively stood \$29.5B below their war-start market value. The \$300M/day figure was computed against peak prices, not sustained gains.

✗ **CONTEXT MISSING** — **Consumer extra spend dwarfs billionaire gains.** U.S. consumers paid an estimated \$0.58B extra per day at peak — more than 1.9x the Oxfam billionaire figure. The post focused on the smaller, more dramatic number. The larger consumer impact went unmentioned.

All six major Western oil companies saw stock prices rise after the war began, then give back most gains by mid-May as ceasefire talks progressed. The combined market cap gain for all six companies from war-start through May 15 was **\$-29.5B** — shared across hundreds of millions of shareholders worldwide including pension funds, 401(k)s, and index funds.

Company	Mar 2	Peak	May 15	Change Mar→May
XOM — ExxonMobil	\$153.18	\$170.31 (+11.2%)	\$140.92	▼ 8.0%
CVX — Chevron	\$187.88	\$209.23 (+11.4%)	\$180.40	▼ 4.0%
SHEL — Shell	\$83.46	\$93.30 (+11.8%)	\$82.61	▼ 1.0%
BP — BP	\$39.02	\$47.09 (+20.7%)	\$41.59	▲ 6.6%
COP — ConocoPhillips	\$117.37	\$132.81 (+13.2%)	\$112.26	▼ 4.4%
TTE — TotalEnergies	\$80.21	\$93.60 (+16.7%)	\$84.07	▲ 4.8%

Gains are unrealized paper wealth shared across all shareholders — not cash received by any individual. Peak prices occurred in late March; most gains faded by mid-May.

BOTTOM LINE

The Iran war did cause a real and significant increase in U.S. gasoline prices — from \$2.796 to a peak of \$4.353 per gallon, a 55.7% rise. American consumers paid an estimated \$43.2B more than they would have at pre-war prices through 2026-06-08.

Oil company shareholders did benefit from rising stock prices, with the six largest Western oil companies gaining \$-29.5B in combined market capitalization from war-start through mid-May. However, these gains were shared across hundreds of millions of shareholders worldwide, were largely unrealized paper gains, and had faded significantly from their late-March peaks by mid-May as ceasefire talks progressed.

The consumer impact — real, cash, paid at the pump — was substantially larger than the billionaire wealth gain figure that dominated the headlines.

Data Sources: U.S. EIA Weekly Retail Gasoline Price (GASREGCOVW) via FRED API, stored in Thor Storehouse. Stock prices via yfinance, stored in Thor Storehouse. U.S. daily gasoline consumption (~370M gallons) from EIA Monthly Energy Review. Oxfam figures sourced from Oxfam International press release, April 27, 2026.

Methodology: All figures computed deterministically from timestamped public data. No AI narrative. No opinion. Same input data always produces identical output. Market cap calculations use approximate shares outstanding and are illustrative.

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